



ROAD TO RICHES

- Mayawati had conceived the 1,000-km project in September 2007
- It will reduce the distance between Delhi and Ballia by 10 hours
- The builders would acquire 30,000 acre of 'wasteland' in Etah, Allahabad and Mirzapur to set up 'investment region'
- The project would ensure smooth transport while stopping erosion of land and saving lakhs of hectares of cultivable land through flood control embankments on the Ganga

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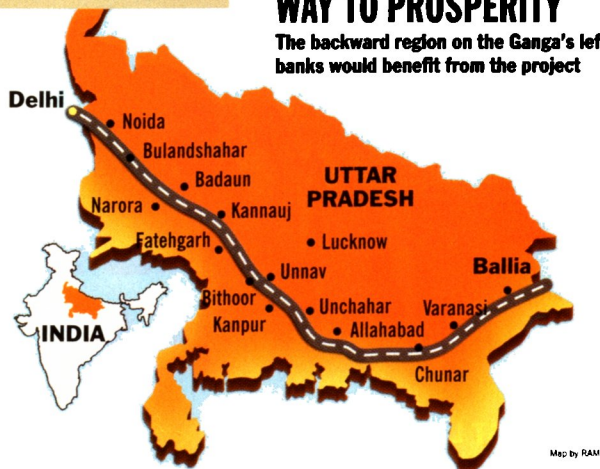
AP PHOTO/VIJAY MIGLANI

Cabinet Secretary Shashank Shekhar Singh, had visualised the project three years ago which was prompted by the plight of the farmers living on the flood-devastated northern banks of the Ganga. With a G.T. Road, built in the 16th century by Sher Shah Suri, feeding the right banks of the Ganga, she felt the large backward region on the left banks would get the opportunity of joining the mainstream of development with an expressway. To translate this into reality, the Government would act as a facilitator. But the Opposition was in no mood to relent and kept raising issues like displacement of farmers, fertile land being grabbed by builders and a handful of officials around the chief minister plundering the state's resources. The argument was simple: the Government owned only 5 per cent of the land required for the project, so the maximum percentage would have to be acquired from farmers.

The chief minister clarified that

WAY TO PROSPERITY

The backward region on the Ganga's left banks would benefit from the project



Map by RAM

project during the BSP-BJP coalition regime in 2003. However, her successor Mulayam had stalled it on grounds of "corruption and loot". Justice S.R. Mishra Committee was set up to probe the charges but nothing could be substantiated. With the re-launch of the Taj Expressway and launch of the Noida-Ballia Ganga Expressway, a unique network would be created bringing the national capital region within the reach of the state's farmers, artisans and industrialists.

Mayawati, says her strategist and

builders would require only 30,000 acre of "infertile and wasteland" to set up "investment regions" along the expressway in lieu of huge capital investment. Of this, 20,000 acre would be acquired in Etah and 10,000 acre in Meja tehsil of Allahabad. The industries to be set up in these investment regions would transform the area and spawn direct and indirect employment for three lakh people in about 500 large and 7,000 medium and small-scale units. The entry of BPO and IT companies will open a window of opportunities for

technical and educated unemployed.

The large-scale industrialisation will ultimately lead to the setting up of various technical and vocational training institutes which will include 35 industrial training institutes, 20 polytechnics, 10 engineering colleges, five medical colleges and several paramedical schools. About 20,000 students would benefit from these institutions and an equal number of people would be employed here. Nearly 500 large and small agro-based industries would be part of the investment regions which would directly benefit the farmers. Traditional industries at Bhadohi, Kannauj and Khurja would get a new lease of life while the expressway project is also expected to be helpful to the economic uplift of weavers and artisans. Besides, it would ensure the revival of ancient cities like Mirzapur and Bithoor.

Yet with the Opposition's arguments gaining credence, Mayawati has changed tack and formulated what she calls an "unprecedented and unique" rehabilitation and compensation package. Explains Ravindra Singh, principal secretary, PWD, who is also the CEO of Uttar Pradesh Expressway Authority, the rehabilitation policy would be implemented by the builders before the project starts. "If it's not implemented, then the builders would not get land," he adds. The unique part of the policy is that the land owners would have the liberty to convert up to 10 per cent of their compensation towards their acquired land into shares of the companies involved in the construction of the project. The Government will also allot free residential plots—150 sq m in urban areas and 250 sq m in rural areas—to those whose land would be acquired. Besides, they would be entitled to a 15 per cent quota in the allotment of flats or plots in the proposed industrial pockets.

But with the SEZ issue having led to controversies elsewhere in the country and even a reversal of policy, Mayawati's grand scheme could still face tough hurdles. Going by the tit for tat between her and Mulayam and each stalling the other's projects, there's every chance that the economically backward state could once again become hostage to vendetta politics. ■